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ABSTRACT

Inclusivity is a contemporary social discourse that calls for practices enabling equal, just, or fair access to resources and opportunities. Designers and researchers are increasingly requested and pressured to take an active role as agents of inclusion. However, many current framings take positive outlooks at face value and do not address the root causes of exclusion. As researchers affiliated with design, we offer a critical discussion of this concept by problematizing and reflexively engaging with it. We position the argument that inclusion is always a meeting of agencies. Instead of striving to adopt and affirm ideal types, we acknowledge the value of recognizing the agencies made visible through frictions, which invite possibilities for negotiation and refusal as outcomes. Hence, inclusion frames relational practices with results that cannot be controlled—meaning that positive and negative effects coexist as part of social dynamism.

Keywords

design research
negotiation
plurality
more-than-human
contestation

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INTRODUCTION: PROBLEMATIZING INCLUSION

Inclusivity is a contemporary social discourse that calls for practices enabling equal, just, or fair access to resources and opportunities. Resources and opportunities refer to the material and immaterial conditions that allow people to participate in specific social ways and functions, especially those deemed as social commitments or having a positive social impact (Hoffmann, 2021). Hence, practicing inclusion is seen as a conduit that opens a world of relations to actors who would otherwise be kept outside of such relations.

Actors subject to being 'included' are often assumed to be denied or deprived of opportunities, thus confined outside this world of socially positive relations. In this paper, we problematize this understanding of inclusion,

particularly considering how design discourses have popularized inclusivity and encoded it into practices such as collaborative and participatory design. We argue that the distinction between 'includer' and 'included' is fundamental to critiques of inclusivity, not intending to replace one definition with another, but to allow fostering a position that has implications in how we work with and deal with inclusivity at a conceptual level.

Mainstream design discourses call for embracing frameworks that enable the participation of others in design decisions by acknowledging their diversity and potential for collaboration. Designers and researchers like us are increasingly impelled to take an active role as agents of inclusion—by making inclusion possible in and through design. However, many of these frameworks take positive outlooks at face value without addressing how they continue to reproduce the relations and power dynamics that might be the root causes of exclusion in the first place. Concerns about participatory and inclusive practices in design have been raised by many other researchers (Gheerawo, 2016; K. Holmes, 2018), as so have calls to action (Costanza-Chock, 2020; Yanicki et al., 2015) and manifestos (Hamraie & Fritsch, 2019) that critique existing practices and methods aiming at 'doing' and 'being' inclusive.

Many of us internalize the expectation that we, as designers and researchers, must be 'agents of inclusion'. This obligation lives within the territory of our discipline, whether we consciously embrace it or not. It is a role we carry into the classrooms where we teach and the groups we work with. While we acknowledge our capacities and willingness to be inclusive, we also recognize that our practices can inadvertently support the root causes of deep-seated inequalities and uneven power dynamics. This tension calls for ongoing critical reflection on how we negotiate our roles as designers and researchers, and on the unintended consequences of our efforts toward inclusion.

We begin the problematization of inclusion by questioning it from within our own experiences and by approaching inclusion as a matter of agency. Taking this perspective means reconsidering what inclusion can be, how it is enacted, and by whom. We place our experiences at the center to formulate and elaborate on how inclusion can be a source of friction. This paper aims to position this understanding of inclusion.

We offer a critical discussion that emerged from multiple conversations and encounters around inclusion—a concept we no longer see as a ready-made model or framework for dealing with society, but as an issue requiring our active and reflexive engagement. We present ourselves as a heterogeneous group of early-career researchers with diverse lived experiences and research projects—varying in scope, scale, geography, and tempo-

rality. In this positioning we also consider the different meanings we give to inclusion and how we approach it. In the conversations that led to this paper, we agreed that inclusion is not merely a matter of gathering individuals or granting conditions to those previously left out, as such acts can only continue the imposterization of inclusion (O. Holmes et al., 2022). Moreover, we questioned why the emphasis on bringing everyone into the mainstream is so strong, and whether inclusion also constitutes the imposition of a prescribed 'right way' of being.

The following section discusses some conceptual underpinnings of social inclusion as a necessary background. While inclusion appears to be a well-established topic in design, its role as a mechanism of social making is not as well-known.

A CONCEPTUAL UNDERPINNING OF INCLUSION

Social inclusion is difficult to generalize, with definitions and framings varying across disciplinary traditions, epistemic communities, and practices. In design, conventional definitions often focus on human factors and ergonomics, such as human-computer interaction (cf. K. Holmes, 2018). These definitions refer to inclusion as a process of adapting the physical features of products to the diverse capacities of diverse humans (Reed & Monk, 2006). Inclusion has also been expanded to encompass psychological aspects of use, including well-being through mental health, by addressing users' wants and aspirations (e.g., Bichard et al., 2006). Furthermore, social inclusion can also be considered a targeted goal. However, the normative goals of social inclusion remain unclear due to multiple and conflicting definitions in research and policies (Simplican et al., 2015), making it contingent upon specific socio-historic-material arrangements.

Social inclusion is a central concept in participatory design. It is prominently featured as a key orientation in projects focused on public infrastructure and policymaking. However, within participatory processes, social inclusion is also a contentious concept that is not free from contestation. For example, Asenbaum and Hanusch (2021) criticize it as an insufficient contribution to democratic processes.

Inclusion in the public sector springs from a different context and has a different aim than inclusion in the private sector—as the means and aims vary. In the former, inclusion is a way to ensure that governments are taking care of—or have control over—all the people in their administrative areas (Asenbaum & Hanusch, 2021). In the latter, it offers the opportunity to reach more market segments. Third-sector inclusion—for example, in socially driven commercial enterprises—also aims to expand social benefits to more

people, regardless of their initial demands (Gheerawo, 2016).

These diverse understandings of inclusion demonstrate that the concept is not universal. The conceptual boundaries of inclusivity have expanded from bodies and cognitions to cultural aspects and normative goals for equity and justice, with political and economic implications. However, this expansion does not imply the erasure of previous understandings but rather signals different—and sometimes diverging—approaches to inclusion.

Social Inclusion as Agencies

In view of further expanding the concept, we argue that inclusion is always a matter of agencies mediating in—and introducing—material and symbolic entities. We borrow the concept of agency from the Actor-Network Theory, drawing on Latour (2005), which assumes that agency exists only in the enacting of actors when relating to other actors. In other words, agencies emerge from relations. Agencies can be recognized both by the actors' actions and observations (or research). This implies that the definition of agency in inclusion is relative to those partaking in acts they recognize as inclusive. However, simultaneous agencies of inclusion also exist in acts that are not recognized as inclusion but are nevertheless enacted.

Our position develops from the argument that inclusion is not universal because neither relations nor the agencies within them are universal or fixed. Furthermore, by introducing material and symbolic aspects as means of inclusion, these relations are mediated and opportunities for alternative agencies are opened. For example, concepts such as empathy—widely used in design thinking (Bennett & Rosner, 2019; Devecchi & Guerrini, 2017; Gasparini, 2015, to name a few)—presuppose an agency that prescribes the mindset practitioners must adopt and the preparations before engaging with others. Another instance is the mediation of relations through the agencies of things. For example, a ramp designed for wheelchair users may also act on the mobility patterns of non-wheelchair users.

Some specific aspects of conventional human inclusion are undoubtedly desirable for most people—for example, providing physical solutions that enable them to move and act autonomously and independently at their own will. Unfortunately, other agencies introduced through efforts toward inclusion may lead to oppression, invalidation, and even the erasure of people and other entities. Even actors who, through their agencies, demonstrate a desire to be included in other social groups can generate problems. For instance, Day and Parnell (2003) use social inclusion as a desirable feature for architectural practice, enabling people to acquire a sense of respect for their lives by participating in the definition of architectural projects they

will inhabit. Nevertheless, problems may arise when the desire for inclusion involves fulfilling the aspirations of particular lifestyles, as seen in the articulations of needs and satisfiers described by Max-Neef (1998).

Even when inclusion expands to agencies, designers can still fail to consider hegemonic or dominant agencies and the relations that structure them: we are confronted with the utopian ideal of 'designing for everyone'. The paradox of inclusion is that it is always impossible to include and please everyone without excluding or overlooking someone (Bianchin & Heylighen, 2017). Inclusion thus becomes an unattainable goal—an 'ideal type' that we constantly strive for—and a generative source of friction regarding what constitutes a 'good life' (Hamraie & Fritsch, 2019).

We contend that inclusion is not one particular agency but always implies bringing in entities that can alter the state of relations of agencies, creating an intrinsically inclusive sociality that is "made in entangling relations with significant others" (Tsing, 2013, p. 27). In addition, inclusion is not a positive or negative practice, as it is more nuanced through the changes that redefine the relational agency of the various actors involved— both human and more-than-human. Inclusion is paradoxical: to include means to bring something in, yet the agencies of the entities brought in may resist their inward movement or even manifest as contestation or refusal.

CONVERSATIONS ON INCLUSION

Our position on social inclusion as meetings of agencies is challenging, as we do not intend to generalize the concept. On the contrary, our perspectives connect with the frustration provoked by prescriptive models and idealized archetypes. For practical reasons and the purpose of this paper, it becomes necessary to explain our common ground of experiences and meanings around inclusion.

Here, we refer to ourselves as the authors who propose this positioning of inclusion. As a group of diverse individuals, we bring into conversation different experiences that taint our comprehension of inclusion and its agencies. While we differ in personal, cultural, professional, and academic backgrounds, we share a common trait: identifying ourselves as early-career researchers. Most of us came from different countries and were brought together within a shared institutional setting—where our agencies met.

As a group, we first came together through daily encounters in a shared open-space office, provided as an inclusive space for PhD candidates and research assistants. While this setup fostered a sense of community based on similarities, it also set us apart—as young and non-permanent staff—which, in turn, framed our agencies within the structures of academia.

In that space, we came to reflect that one can be included—be brought in—while still experiencing a socio-material division from other staff members within the same institutional structure. Such dissonance became evident for us, though it is not uncommon in academia, where research norms, institutional practices, and arrangements are often 'elevated as ideal' (Camargo et al., 2024), thereby undermining the value that plural identities could have when brought in and together.

Furthermore, we recognize that certain steps— such as providing a physical space—are taken in the name of inclusion. However, these steps can only be meaningfully addressed by acknowledging how they signify a separation between the includer and the included—in this case, ourselves—and how they limit our capacity for acting in the idealized roles we are expected to perform while being subjected to that inclusion.

Such autoethnographic reflections exemplify our approach to understanding inclusion and are not limited to our academic position. They are also rooted in our fluid other identities—such as gender, age, nationality, skills, and relationships—which, when intertwined within our social fabric, shape agencies and relationalities. Through a reflexive process spanning over two years of coming together, sharing experiences, and analyzing conversations, we engaged in a collective process of learning and unlearning, agreeing and disagreeing, understanding and questioning. Our conversations were grounded in our group's diversity and brought together experiences and critical viewpoints from our work as researchers.

While we are affiliated with design as a discipline, our research is diverse, and the topics we cover are too broad to allow a single definition of inclusion to encompass them all. Our research projects span issues such as policy, norm-criticality, migration, communities, technologies, postmodernism, more-than-human worlds, alternative futures, and common sense. These topics involve both material and symbolic entities that are brought into relation to constitute a socio-material assembly. Thus, through our research process, we also participate in constructing the social world. Most importantly for this paper, we include or exclude by enacting the agencies embedded in our research process.

For instance, when considering the perception of reality, agencies point towards differences in how the world is perceived—and the actions taken—by those who include, as opposed to those who are included. In Rishi's (2021) work with migrant workers, this is evident in how inclusion can overlook the motivations of the workers themselves, emphasizing this distinction. Similarly, Valladares' experience participating in local governments illustrates how perceptions of inclusion are also transferred into material means, making

them subject to agencies that may go unnoticed, such as knowledge disparities, power structures, and the individual's self-awareness of being included (Valladares & Pettersen, 2023). From a third perspective, inclusivity should also be a reflexive practice, wary of reproducing existing structures. Rayaprolu articulates how even situational and highly contextual aspects of community research can get lost in generalized views of inclusivity, deeming them as procedural and methodical, thereby affirming and replicating existing structures that fetishize and homogenize the notions and concepts of inclusion. Thus, inclusion can become laden with friction when actors and agencies are not acknowledged, as Tarcan also argues in her critique that designers often create hierarchical distinctions that prioritize humans over non-human entities (Tarcan et al., 2023).

As noted in such research dialogues, our bringing together of multiple and diverse perspectives does not lead to a universal understanding of inclusion that can be instrumentalized to guarantee a successful outcome. On the contrary, in approaching shame as the entity included, Trondsen (2024) critiques our fixation on—and desire to—construct ideal types as a means to formulate aspirational modes of being and doing. Just as shame can act as a mechanism to control the narrative of who is included and excluded, Ortega Alvarado's research on the concept of 'circular economy' (Ortega Alvarado et al., 2023) implicates inclusion as a function of power that legitimizes what can be spoken and even thought about. By considering thoughts on why material resources are used as part of a socio-material assembly, he highlights how inclusion operates in acts of contestation or legitimization of agencies against the filter of what is considered normal— commonly referred to as the *status quo*.

Rather than the commonalities in our experience and understanding of inclusion, it is the heterogeneity, differences, and existence of friction in our research perspectives what establish a common ground. This foundation allows us to share a position that understands inclusion as fluid and dynamic relations between actors when their agencies meet—where the possibility of friction within inclusion is not discarded. Instead of striving to adopt and affirm ideal types, our position acknowledges the value of recognizing the agencies made visible through friction, enabling negotiation or refusal among a plurality of actors, perspectives, and worlds.

A CRITIQUE OF INCLUSIVITY IN THREE FRICTIONS

Ask a hundred people what inclusion means, and you'll get a hundred different answers. Ask them what it means to be excluded and the

> answer will be uniformly clear: It's when you're left out. (K. Holmes, 2018, p. 4)

Building on our previous reflection on how inclusion is discussed in our research and experiences, we devise ways to further challenge prevailing notions of inclusivity. Our conversations, reflections, and engagements on the topic have formed the basis for the insights presented in this section. We frame our experiences with different understandings of inclusion through several agencies and forms of knowledge.

In our position, we contend that there is always an 'included' and an 'excluded', as well as an 'includer' and an 'excluder'. These roles imply agencies for both the 'includer' and 'included' that may not be symmetrical in terms of opportunities for action. Furthermore, social conditions may alter, limit, or even eliminate the space for negotiation, resulting in inclusion or exclusion occurring without any dialogue or process of acknowledgment. This lack of negotiation can lead to impositions through force, as seen in colonialism.

Considering the agencies outlined above, and based on our experiences and conversations around inclusion, we have identified three frictions:

1. The framing of people and their agencies creates two distinct positions between the categories of includer and included. However, recognizing actors—regardless of whether they are symbolic or material entities—within these categories depends on who or what initiates the act of inclusion and how those being included respond. An actor framed as 'included' may reject this inclusion and, in doing so, become an 'excluder'. Moreover, being an 'excluder' cannot be categorized a priori as either negative or positive: such categorization is an effect of the power dynamics between those who include and those who are included.

2. The formation of ideal types involves the creation of standards for social relations and ways of acknowledging what is understood as left out (excluded). Conventional framings of inclusion often idealize the 'included', forcing them to conform to established norms while concealing the potential frictional agencies that emerge. However, we argue that those who are included may not always want this inclusion, leading to resistance or the introduction of unexpected elements that redefine the terms of inclusion. As conventional framings of inclusion often rely only on 'positive' outlooks, such resistance may be interpreted as a 'failure of inclusion'. This one-sided focus neglects the agency of those who resist inclusion into a mainstream system—as in cases of forced assimilation.

3. The inclusion of other entities contests human-centeredness: these more-than-human entities contribute to the construction of the social world but are often engaged in instrumental ways. As a third friction, we raise discussion on the exclusion and inclusion of entities that are not human, drawing on scholars who emphasize the importance of understanding and acknowledging these relationships. Relevant frameworks include the more-than-human world, referring to 'the earthly nature' (Abram, 1996); intra-actions, which suggest that humans and non-humans are part of the same entanglement, continuously shaping and transforming one another (Barad, 2003); and perspectives that call for acknowledging the entangled relationships among all entities, as humans are in nature and nature is in humans (Åsberg & Braidotti, 2018). From this perspective, we contend that while inclusion is inherently reductive, it should be recognized that any attempt at inclusion may bring in more than what is anticipated.

With these frictions we emphasize that acts of inclusion should also consider challenging their purposes by acknowledging the acts of contestation, in addition to challenging the *status quo* and human-centeredness in design. We offer these frictions as a way to further rethink and expand the framing of inclusion as a matter of agencies. Ultimately, we argue that whenever inclusion is brought up, friction inevitably emerges. This compels us to question and reconsider current framings and norms on the topic. Our positioning, articulated through these three frictions, offers an opening for those who struggle to engage with inclusion as it is conventionally framed.

SOCIAL INCLUSION AS FRICTIONAL NEGOTIATIONS OF AGENCIES

Although inclusivity as a discourse is often framed through its positive outlooks—promoting more equal, just, or fair societies—, in practice these are undoubtedly driven by a power dynamic that centers the ways of being of those who act as 'includers', while marginalizing the ways of being and doing of those who act as 'included'. As a result, all inclusion is necessarily preceded by acts of exclusion. These exclusions are seldom immediate; rather, they follow long trajectories that span generations and cross geographies—historically motivated by biases against bodily conditions, class, disease, gender, race, sexual orientation, ethnic differences, and origin.

> [Inclusion] does not mean that they all have the same say in the matter, but that they all [are] present in the mode that makes the decision as difficult as possible, that precludes any short-cut or simplification. (Stengers, 2005, p. 1003)

Although some definitions of exclusion help to understand the contingencies faced by subjects brought in through social inclusion (e.g., Silver, 1994), we contend that the shortcomings of inclusion are not definitional. The dynamism of exclusion and inclusion is not a binary condition but rather a matter of scale within a continuum of inclusion/exclusion that frames which relations are deemed socially positive or negative (O'Reilly, 2005; Phillips, 2008). This perspective is key to avoiding the reduction of friction to mere barriers.

Some authors assert that inclusion is not simply the opposite of exclusion but rather a process of constant interplay that continually generates new inclusive/exclusive conditions and possibilities (Armstrong et al., 2011). This interplay represents a form of dynamism that can be interpreted as frictional and counterproductive to the positive outlooks typically expected by design.

In creative endeavors, friction can serve as both a cautionary note and a temptation to limit or avoid. Taking the consequences of inclusion seriously means being aware of frictions and the many ways in which success can signify the erasure of the agencies of others who are supposedly included. As such, frictions are not barriers to be avoided by design, but points of reflection on what is being designed and the beings and doings that inclusion helps to sustain—and eliminate.

In simpler terms—specifically in the context of design—the emphasis should not be on striving for a universal idea of inclusion, but on challenging ourselves to break free from our current discursive values and from culturally and historically flattened perspectives. This is exemplified in Trondsen's (2024) research on shame, which considers social inclusion as an invitation to engage with what is already uncomfortable and confrontational. To this end, a confrontational use of inclusion is not intended to be harmful, but to engage people in thought-provoking dialogues filled with friction, pushing discursive boundaries and challenging what is considered possible, acceptable, reasonable, or even morally correct.

Here, we find the opportunity to raise two questions about the acts of inclusion—as a path towards a research agenda. First, by what standards are exclusions evaluated? For example, how, when, and by whom is it decided that specific populations must perform certain social functions? Second, how is it decided which society or societal functions are inclusive, and which must be included? This second question concerns the asymmetries between those who include and those who are supposed to be included, mainly because it addresses the hegemonic processes of socialization—of one group dominating others through ways that are not always evident or explicit to the dominated (Lears, 1985).

As our final remarks—although not expanded on in this paper—we acknowledge numerous approaches that open ways for discussing inclusion and exclusion from broader perspectives. These include frameworks such as design for autonomy (Escobar, 2018), ontological design (Fry, 2022; Willis, 2006), and speculative and critical design (Dunne & Raby, 2013). These and many other approaches offer pathways for inclusivity in design by acknowledging the power dynamics that result from an agency based on bringing others into any given relational framework.

In conclusion, we position inclusion as the meeting—or clash—of agencies. Our positioning is based on recognizing three frictions that emerge from our clash with the concept—by refusing and negotiating its meaning as part of our process of researching and thinking together. We have come to understand that inclusion is not a straightforward concept but rather encompasses a negotiation that requires careful consideration of power dynamics and social relations. We highlight the importance of avoiding impositions and embracing pluralities in the pursuit of inclusivity. ⊡

Author's note
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